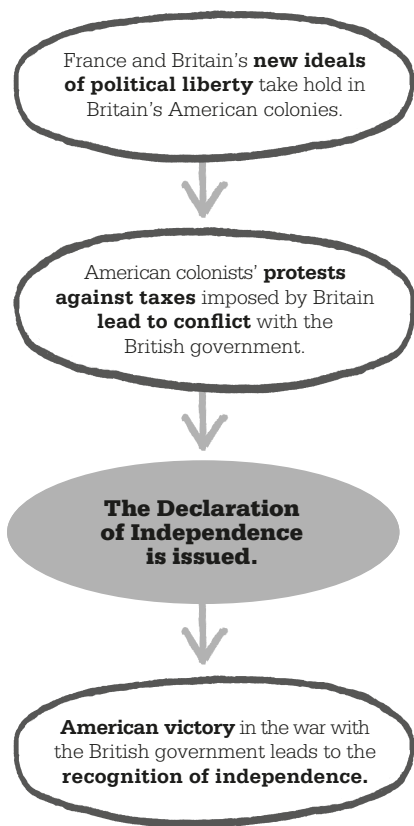




reprisals from Britain. In the same way, as many as 500,000 of a population of 2.5 million remained loyal to the British crown to the end of the conflict, many subsequently settling in Canada.

The conflict takes shape

It would take a drawn-out and bitterly fought war to make independence into reality. Britain was determined to assert what it saw as its legitimate rule, while the hastily assembled forces of the nascent United States were no less determined to assert what they saw as their right to independence. The two modest armies—Britain's, because of the difficulties of sending forces en masse to America; the colonists', because they

consistently lacked the means to raise and equip any substantial fighting force—confronted each other in a series of minor engagements over six years.

At their peak, the American forces numbered scarcely 40,000 and had almost no navy at all. Britain deployed about the same number of soldiers but in addition had a vastly greater number of ships. In 1778, however, France declared support for the colonists and sent 5,000 troops and a substantial fleet. Facing certain defeat, in October 1781, the British surrendered at Yorktown, Virginia. The war would not formally end for another year, but in every important respect, the colonists—and their French allies—had dealt a huge blow to their British masters.

The French involvement in the creation of this new nation owed everything to a desire to reverse the humiliations of the Seven Years' War. But the debts incurred would, ironically, be among the many causes of the bankruptcy of the French crown that led to the French Revolution in 1789. There was a profound irony, too, in absolutist France seeking to win Americans the freedoms that it was unwilling to accord its own citizens.

Revolutionary ideals

At the heart of the American Revolution was the new political philosophy encapsulated by the Declaration of Independence. It was the work of a distinctly patrician Virginian, a haughty, wealthy slaveholder named Thomas Jefferson. He was one of a committee of five charged with writing the Declaration, yet the two drafts it went through in June 1776 were almost entirely his own. It is »

“ These United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States.

Richard Henry Lee
Proposed resolution at the Second Continental Congress (June 1776)